

MEXICO CITY MEXICO



Tackling the Taco in Mexico

Informal, exuberant, fast, yet satisfying, tacos are perfectly in tune with Mexico City. It was the powerhouse of pre-Hispanic America and still burns brightly today, mixing ancient traditions with high-tech, urban sophistication. Whether you're in arty Roma, the *centro histórico* or well-heeled Polanco, pick your *taquería* and enjoy a taco or two alongside the 25 million locals.



Without setting foot outside the massive metropolis of Mexico City, travelers can experience cultures nearly 700 years apart, all in the midst of teeming humanity, streaming traffic, and – more often than not – the unmistakable sound of an approaching mariachi band. Mexico's vast capital city is full of urban energy. Made up of a series of neighborhoods, each has a very distinct character, and many warrant exploration. It's almost impossible to miss the historic downtown, which includes the huge Zócalo (the central square) and the ruins of the Aztec Templo Mayor (the Great Temple). The best hotels are found in the elegant Polanco district, which sits alongside the vast green space of Chapultepec Park, near the renowned Anthropology Museum. Just outside the city, the Pyramids of the Sun and the Moon rise up in ancient Teotihuacán.

In such heady surroundings, the tasty, speedy taco could have been invented with the regular and robust refueling of Mexico City's overwhelmed visitors in mind. In fact, however, its origins may well date back

as far as the Mayans and Aztecs. It makes use of that most traditional of Mexican foodstuffs – the corn tortilla – and the ubiquitous taco is a mainstay of the national diet. The name “taco” is a generic way to describe some kind of filling wrapped inside a tortilla, so it's essentially a Mexican-style sandwich. Many of the country's indigenous crops feature as fillings, such as chili peppers, tomatoes, avocados, and beans, usually accompanied by some type of meat or fish.

Most common at lunch time, tacos make ideal late-night snacks too, with recipes and ingredients varying according to family traditions and regional influences. The *taco al pastor*, or shepherd-style taco, is a favorite; this usually contains pork, sliced directly and showily from the rotisserie into the tortilla, although it can also be made with chicken or shredded steak. Fishy versions commonly consist of grilled or fried fish or shrimp along with lettuce or cabbage. The trick is to pile two or three of your choice onto a gaudy plastic plate, then retire to the condiments counter for lime, onion, cilantro, and guacamole, topped off with fiery salsa. Roll, fold, and devour – no cutlery required.



Above A *taquería* (taco restaurant) often has a *maestro taquero*, a master-taco maker

What Else to Eat

European and North American chain restaurants churning out “Mexican” dishes do no justice to a varied and imaginative national cuisine that makes full use of fresh indigenous produce. When you've had all the tacos you can take, be sure to try **tamales**, tasty and inexpensive snacks often sold from baskets by street sellers and once eaten by pre-Colombians. A *tamal* is a steamed parcel of corn dough with a sweet or savory filling, wrapped within a corn husk or banana leaf. Alternatively, seek out a **torta** (sandwich) or tortilla containing **nopal**: chopped, de-spined prickly pear cactus “paddles,” or leaf pads, which look and taste a little like avocado. Although Mexico City is inland, the fish dishes are superb; tuck into shrimp in tangy sauces from Veracruz or whole fish fresh from the market, accompanied by hot, fresh salsa.

The Best Places to Eat Tacos

El Califa inexpensive

There are four El Califa *taquerías* in Mexico City, but the Condesa branch is the easiest to find, and it buzzes with a healthy mix of visitors and locals. This canteen-style restaurant is sufficiently stark and industrial to feel “authentic,” but the quality of its food and hygiene make it a perfect entry to the world of the *taquería* – start here, and head for the street stalls when you and your palate are ready!

Vegetarians will struggle here, but carnivores can choose from various cuts of beef steak, rib, or chop, and chicken or pork. El Califa's specialty is to serve the meat griddle-roasted and in whole pieces, rather than minced. Tortillas come to you fresh from the oven, liberally laden with melted Oaxaca cheese, golden from the grill. Choose an *al pastor* (pork in guajillo chili salsa and grilled pineapple) and your marinated meat will be shaved off the spit in front of you. The *gaonera* (a slice of tender beef fillet with raw tomatillo sauce in a thick, handmade tortilla) is delicious. Take care when ordering from the salsa menu – they're all hot, despite what the menu might say.

Altata 22, Condesa; open from 1 PM “until the early hours”; www.elcalifa.com.mx/califa.html

Also in Mexico City

El Borrego Viudo (“the widowed sheep”) (*Avenida Revolución Tacubaya; inexpensive*) is certainly authentic and well worth a late-night pilgrimage to this less-than-glamorous spot alongside the viaduct. Armies of servers clad in chef's whites bustle around the cavernous feeding house, taking tacos out to drive-through clients in the huge parking lot. Open 24 hours a day, it specializes in tacos *al pastor*.

Also in Mexico

Around six hours' drive southeast of Mexico City, Oaxaca is one of Mexico's most beautiful colonial cities. Follow the billowing smoke from **Mercado 20 de Noviembre**, an atmospheric and inexpensive food market, to find sizzling tacos. The stands are mostly frequented by local people, and best at lunch time; pick the stand with the longest line.

Around the World

Serving from a small gazebo with the menu propped up against it on a blackboard, **Buen Provecho** (*inexpensive*) is a one-man band consisting of Arturo Ortega Rodríguez, who serves up what must surely be London's most authentic Mexican food. He's in Waterloo (Lower Marsh) lunchtime market during the week and Elephant and Castle market on Sundays. Tacos come with a choice of marinated meat fillings, and the salsa is for sale, should you want to reproduce the experience at home.